

Before the Sermon



A NOTEBOOK FOR THOUGHTFUL READING

BEFORE —*the*— SERMON

Sitting With Scripture

GAO KAB

Before the Sermon: Sitting With Scripture
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This notebook is a reading companion, not a replacement for sermons. It does not interpret Scripture, and it does not tell you what to believe.

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THIS NOTEBOOK BELONGS TO

BEGUN

TRANSLATION I AM READING

*There is no right pace for this. Some readings will take an evening. Some will
take a season.*

What this notebook is

Before the Sermon: Sitting With Scripture is a guided reading notebook designed to help people engage Scripture slowly, thoughtfully, and without intimidation. It is not a devotional, commentary, or theology guide. It does not explain passages or tell readers what to believe.

Instead, it offers a structured way to sit with the text, notice what is written, reflect honestly, and build confidence as a reader — before sermons, summaries, or conclusions. The notebook is meant to be used alongside the Bible, not instead of it.

WHO IT IS FOR

- People who feel intimidated by the Bible
- Readers who don't know how to read Scripture on their own
- Christians who want to slow down their reading
- Seekers or non-Christians who are curious but cautious
- Anyone who wants to engage the Bible without pressure, performance, or expertise

No prior knowledge, belief, or background is assumed.

What makes it different

THIS NOTEBOOK DOES NOT

Interpret Scripture for you

Push application or action

Assume belief or expertise

ITS PURPOSE IS TO

Change how you read

Train attention and patience

Allow meaning to surface slowly

Build honest reading confidence

Confusion, silence, and “I don’t know” are treated as valid outcomes.

THE VOICE OF THIS NOTEBOOK

Calm

not authoritative

Invitational

not instructional

Reflective

not prescriptive

Gentle

but serious

It avoids religious jargon, moralizing language, and pressure to apply or conclude.

Three movements

The notebook consists primarily of repeating guided spreads designed to be used during Scripture reading sessions. Each one moves through the same three motions.



1 Observe

Notice what the text actually says — repetition, emphasis, and voice — without rushing to conclusions.

2 Acknowledge

Acknowledge confusion or discomfort. Sit with questions. There are no right answers required.

3 Decide

Decide what you want to sit with longer. Let meaning surface slowly rather than being imposed.

EACH SPREAD PROMPTS YOU TO

- Observe what the text actually says
- Notice repetition, emphasis, and voice
- Identify assumptions you may be bringing
- Acknowledge confusion without rushing to resolve it
- Reflect on how the passage touches your life
- Choose what you want to sit with longer

The same set of questions repeats throughout to build familiarity and confidence.

Before you begin



Open the Bible to whatever you are reading — a passage from a plan, the text for Sunday, a chapter you keep avoiding. Read it once without a pen. Then read it again with one.

Write the reference and the date at the top of the spread. Then take the six questions in order. They are the same on every spread on purpose: you are not meant to get better at the questions, you are meant to get better at reading.

Short answers are fine. Blank lines are fine. “I don’t know what this means” is a complete answer, and often the most honest one on the page.

Nothing here has to be finished before the sermon. The point is only to have looked, properly, for yourself — so that when someone else explains the text, you meet their reading with one of your own.



You are never being tested here.

Readings

One line per spread. A place to see, later, where you have been.



	DATE	PASSAGE	ONE WORD
01			
02			
03			
04			
05			
06			
07			
08			
09			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			
16			
17			
18			
19			
20			
21			
22			
23			
24			
25			
26			

READINGS · CONTINUED



	DATE	PASSAGE	ONE WORD
27			
28			
29			
30			
31			
32			
33			
34			
35			
36			
37			
38			
39			
40			
41			
42			
43			
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47			
48			
49			
50			
51			
52			

How to use a spread

Every reading takes two facing pages. They are always the same.



Passage · Date

Write the reference exactly as you would say it aloud, and the date. Later this is how you will find your way back.

1 – 2

Observe. What the text actually says, and what keeps pulling at you. Stay on the surface longer than feels natural.

3 – 4

Acknowledge. What you brought with you, and what confused or unsettled you. Nothing has to be solved.

5 – 6

Notice. What you felt, and what you think the text is exploring — not what it teaches, what it is about.

Closing

Decide. One thing to sit with longer. One question the text might be asking of you. A line each; or leave them.

Turn the page.

1. *What does the text actually say?*

Before any meaning: what is written, what is repeated, whose voice is speaking.

2. *What keeps pulling your attention?*

A word, a phrase, a turn you can't get past. You don't have to know why yet.

3. *What are you bringing to it?*

Assumptions, memories, what you've been told this means. Name them so you can set them down.

4. *What confused you, or sat uneasily?*

Questions are welcome here, even uncomfortable ones. Nothing has to resolve.

5. *What did you feel as you read?*

Not what you think you should feel. What you felt.

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Not what it teaches. What it is about.

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Passages I keep returning to

Some texts do not let go. List them here, with a word about why, and come back when you need them.



PASSAGE

WHY IT STAYS

Questions I still carry

Unresolved is allowed. These are not a to-do list. They are the questions worth keeping company with.



- _____
- _____
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- _____

Sitting longer

For the readings that needed more than a spread.



A series of 25 horizontal lines for writing, spanning the width of the page.



Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal lines.



Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal lines.



Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal lines.



Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal lines.



A series of 25 horizontal lines for writing, spanning the width of the page.

AT THE END

If some of these pages are half-empty, nothing went wrong. Silence
was allowed from the start.

What you have now is not a set of answers. It is a record of having
looked — slowly, honestly, on your own — before anyone told you
what to see.



ABOUT

Before the Sermon



A guided reading companion designed to help you engage Scripture slowly, thoughtfully, and without intimidation — before explanation, interpretation, or performance.

This notebook exists to help you engage the Bible thoughtfully and confidently.
It is a reading companion, not a replacement for sermons.

Before the Sermon · Sitting With Scripture

Before the Sermon · 2026

6 × 9 in · 128 pages · cream interior